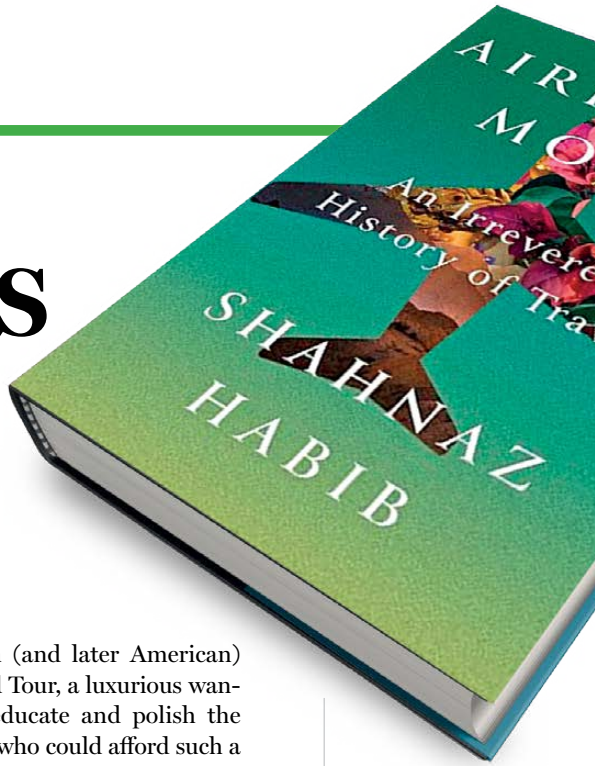
BOOKS

TRAVEL AND ITS DISCONTENTS

Shahnaz Habib's *Airplane Mode* is a sensitive dive into the complex and contentious activity that modern-day travel has devolved into



AIRPLANE MODE
A Passive-Aggressive History of Travel
By Shahnaz Habib
CONTEXT
₹699; 288 pages

It is a relief that Shahnaz Habib has put in writing the long-stewing anxieties of any thinking traveller. The excitement of travel, whether as a paid travel writer or a paying tourist, soon gives way to a creeping realisation that one is a cog in a massive industry that mostly produces construction and transport networks that tourists somehow deserve but residents of beautiful places never seem to get on their own merits.

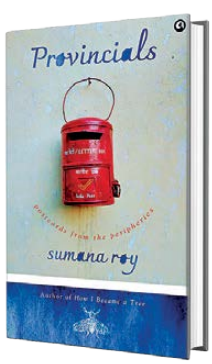
Habib establishes the routines and templates of travel, and the problematic history that got us where we are, with its undeniable national, racial and class hierarchy between the gawker and the gawked-at. She writes of the European/British (and later American) tradition of the Grand Tour, a luxurious wandering that was to educate and polish the class of young people who could afford such a thing. In today's video travelogues, a fiction of "roughing it" varies the tone, but the shrieking OMG freedom of young white travellers is a world away from the cautious ventures of a brown-skinned person in a foreign land.

The author deconstructs every illusion and trope of travel: the relationships between passports and the shape-shifting racism of the Empire, the inequalities baked into the asphalt of the American highways, and the pseudo-discoveries of Europeans who reach and name new places and monuments because

BOOKS

Reclaiming Our Archives

Sumana Roy contests the negative connotations regarding provincials in this thought-provoking book



PROVINCIALS
Postcards from the Peripheries
By Sumana Roy
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹899, 320 pages

In her latest book, Sumana Roy focuses on provincials through "dialects of thought and practice" ranging from personal history, writings (novels, letters, poetry, magazines, cards), films and television, to tourist guides' tales that regale the holiday-maker. Through these stories from across India and the world, Roy "wanted to rescue people stereotyped for their smallness from a pejorative".

Divided into five parts–Postcards, Place, Pedigree, Poetic and Pran–the book examines provincialism and how it is perceived, mainly through books and writers. Each part encompasses a variety of ideas, observations and reminiscences which are structured into short essays. Thus, a piece on D.H. Lawrence also brings in Amit Chaudhuri's *Afternoon Raag*, which leads to a meditation on the prevalence of pronunciation as a signpost of location.

Some parts come across as mere reactions to a piece of work, and I wondered what Roy's thoughts would have been had the original not existed.

In sharing her personal narrative, Roy chronicles the middle-class life of a bygone era. There is a sense of wonder in vignettes of the everyday and the natural world is an important element through it all. Although a whiff of nostalgia is palpable, it is never sentimental.